information that the BSF is allowing people to enter through Islampur, Sitai, Chopra and many other places," she said. Deflecting blame from her party for the influx of "goons", she added, "Borders are not in our hands; they are controlled by the BSF.... If anyone thinks they can allow illegal immigration in Bengal and then accuse the Trinamool, let me make it clear: TMC is not responsible for this." Abhishek, speaking at an event in his Diamond Harbour constituency, echoed Mamata word for word. As Majumdar hit back, saying Mamata was "delusional" in blaming the central paramilitary force, , it was clear the long war of words between the TMC government and the Centre had entered a fresh chapter.

However, another scandal—possibly linked to illegal immigration—has sent shockwaves through Bengal: the discovery of nearly 250 passports issued without proper verification, exposing lapses in the state's passport system. The arrest of nine individuals, allegedly involved in a racket centred around creating false documents to facilitate fake passports, has pushed state authorities to call for an overhaul of the verification process.

Bengal's police chief Rajeev Kumar has written to the ministry of external affairs, advocating stricter verification and distribution protocols. He also issued directives for formally scaling up local police verifications, marking a shift in the responsibility traditionally held by district intelligence branches of the state police, who also give the final approval to applicants' documents. Now, senior police officials like superintendents of police and deputy commissioners will oversee the process. "We are changing the entire approach to passport issuance," Kumar declared at a press conference on December 29. He acknowledged that while passport authorities have accelerated processes to meet growing demands, ensuring security and accuracy must remain paramount.

Bangladesh, slipping into turmoil after the recent popular coup, has seen a mini-exodus of political refugees. In India, though, that has found a matching spike in xenophobic rhetoric, marked by 'busting of gangs' and arrests of alleged terrorists. Bengal's actions are an attempt to be in sync with that norm.

Its probe achieved a breakthrough with the arrest of Manoj Gupta, the alleged mastermind, in Gaighata, North 24 Parganas, on December 28. Operating under the guise of a travel agent, Gupta is believed to have orchestrated the production of fake identity documents, enabling foreign nationals—primarily Bangladeshis—to obtain Indian passports. Another person involved in the racket, former policeman Abdul Hai, was arrested from Kamarpur in North 24 Parganas on January 3 and Rs 12.5 lakh was recovered from his bank account. He allegedly received the amount as bribes for approving passport applications with fake documents.

Internal audits at the Kolkata passport office revealed that around 240 passports based on forged documents were issued, with police overlooking discrepancies during verification. Following a complaint from the passport office, Kolkata Police launched a probe that uncovered the racket. Politics aside, a more robust system of vigilance and accountability will be essential to restore public trust in the process. ■

DRAWING NO LINES

- **The state BJP accuses the TMC government of turning Bengal into a "safe haven" for extremists**
- **Mamata and Abhishek, in turn, accuse New Delhi of facilitating the influx to destabilise state**
- **The recent turmoil in Bangladesh has spiked immigration numbers, heightening scrutiny**
- **A passport racket was busted on Dec. 28 amidst terror fears**



FOULED ENTRY BSF jawans detain Bangladeshis who were trying to cross into India with fake Aadhaar cards, Oct. 15, 2024